

A STILL BREATHING BOOK

She Stopped Waiting for Permission

A story about the day she stopped asking, and started becoming

STILL BREATHING MEDIA

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A short novel about permission, fear, and the year one woman stopped waiting for someone else's yes.

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The Question She Kept Asking

Grace Namono had asked her husband the same question four times in three years, and she was ashamed to realize, standing in the kitchen with the dish towel still in her hands, that she was about to ask it a fifth time.

"I want to talk to you about the tailoring shop again," she said, and even to her own ears her voice had the particular carefulness of someone approaching a sleeping dog. "The space near the market is still available. Nakato said the landlord would hold it another month if I paid a deposit."

Musa didn't look up from his phone right away, which was its own kind of answer. He was not a cruel man — Grace wanted to be fair about that, even now, even in the retelling of this to herself that she did almost nightly in her head. He had never once raised his voice at her about the shop. He simply had a way of receiving the idea that made it very clear, without ever saying so directly, that the idea was not a serious use of anyone's time.

"Grace." He said her name the way he always did when he was about to be reasonable at her. "We've talked about this. Where is the deposit money coming from? What happens to the children's dinner while you're at a shop all day? Who is going to buy dresses from a tailor in this economy?"

Every question was practical. That was the maddening thing about it, the thing that made it so hard to be angry in a way she could point to. He wasn't saying no because he didn't believe in her. He was saying no in the shape of concern, wrapped so carefully in her family's welfare that objecting to it felt like objecting to her own children's dinner.

"I've done the numbers," Grace said. "I showed you the numbers in March. I could start small — alterations first, then—"

"And who takes care of things here while you're figuring out your numbers?" Musa set his phone down now, which meant he considered the conversation serious enough to require his full attention, which somehow made it worse. "I'm not saying never, Grace. I'm saying now is not the time. When the children are older. When we've saved more. There will be a right time for this."

There will be a right time for this. Grace had heard some version of that sentence in nearly every year of her adult life, from nearly every person whose approval she'd learned, very young, to require before she let herself want something. Her mother had said it about Grace's dream of studying fashion design, decades ago, in a different kitchen, in nearly the same tone. Her pastor had said something close

to it two years ago when she'd mentioned wanting to lead a women's group instead of just attending one — *let's pray about the timing, Grace, submission is also a kind of faith.* Even her own mind said it to her, some mornings, in a voice she'd absorbed so early she could no longer tell whose it had originally been.

She went back to the dishes. This was, she would understand much later, the actual pattern — not that she was told no, but that being told no ended the conversation, every time, for nineteen years, because some old and well-trained part of her believed that a no from the right person was simply the truth arriving, rather than one opinion in a decision that was supposed to be hers to make.

That night, after Musa was asleep, Grace sat at the small table in the kitchen with the lamp turned low, and took out the notebook where she kept the numbers he'd asked to see in March. She hadn't stopped working on them, these three years of being told it wasn't the time. She'd just stopped mentioning that she hadn't stopped.

She looked at the figures for a long time. The deposit. The sewing machines she already owned, sitting under a cloth in the spare room, bought secondhand two years ago with money she'd told Musa was for her sister's wedding contribution — a lie so small and so old now that she'd almost forgotten it was one. The three women from church who'd already said, quietly, that they'd buy from her the day she opened. The landlord's month-long hold on the space, which meant this decision, unlike every other one in her marriage, actually had a deadline attached to it whether Musa acknowledged that or not.

Grace closed the notebook. She did not decide anything that night, not in any way she could have named out loud. But she noticed something, sitting there in the low lamp light, that she had never quite let herself notice before: she was going to ask him a fifth time, because that was the pattern, and some part of her already suspected that this time, for reasons she couldn't yet explain to herself, she might not wait for his answer before she acted anyway.

She just didn't know yet what that would cost her, or who she'd have to become to survive the asking.

Nineteen Years of Asking

Grace could trace the habit back further than her marriage, if she was honest about it, though it took her most of that year to be honest about it. It started with her mother, in a small sitting room in Mbale, a woman named Harriet who had wanted to open a produce stall at the trading center and had asked her own husband's permission so many times, across so many years, that by the time Grace was old enough to notice, the asking itself had become the whole relationship between them.

"Your father says the timing isn't right," Harriet would say, folding laundry, not quite meeting Grace's eyes. "Maybe next season." Grace had heard "maybe next season" so many times across her childhood that she'd assumed, the way children assume the shape of their household is the shape of the world, that this was simply how women became business owners — by waiting for a season that a husband would eventually, someday, agree had arrived.

It never arrived for Harriet. She died two years before Grace's wedding, the produce stall still a drawing in the back of a notebook, and Grace had cried at the funeral for reasons she couldn't fully name at the time — grief, yes, but also something closer to recognition, a fear she wouldn't be able to name for another seventeen years: *I am watching what happens to a woman who waits her whole life for a yes that isn't coming.*

The church had reinforced it, gently, the way water reinforces a riverbed — not through cruelty, but through a thousand small sermons about submission and patience that Grace had absorbed as instruction rather than one interpretation among several. *Trust your husband's leadership,* Pastor Okello liked to say. *A wife who waits on God's timing through her husband is a wife who will be blessed in due season.* Grace had wanted, badly, to be the kind of woman that sentence described. She had not stopped to ask whether waiting and submission were actually the same thing, or whether she'd simply found a holy word for a fear she already had.

Her own marriage had simply continued the pattern with a different man's face attached to it. Musa was not Harriet's husband — he did not forbid, he "considered." He did not refuse, he "wasn't sure the timing was right." The words were softer, more modern, more reasonable-sounding, and that was exactly what made them so much harder to argue with. You cannot accuse a man of oppression for asking sensible questions about the family budget. You can only notice, slowly, painfully, that the sensible questions never seem to arrive at yes.

Grace mentioned some of this to her sister Faith one evening on the phone, testing the thought out loud for the first time. "I keep asking him," she said. "Like he's the only person whose opinion is the

actual answer. Like my own opinion is a first draft that needs his approval before it's real."

Faith, two years younger and considerably less patient with these things, didn't hesitate. "Grace, when was the last time you started something without asking anyone first?"

Grace opened her mouth to answer and found, to her genuine surprise, that she didn't have one. Not recently. Not since she was maybe nineteen years old, before Musa, before even some of her mother's caution had fully settled into her bones. Nineteen years old. Nineteen years of asking. The math arrived unbidden and sat there in her chest like a stone she hadn't noticed swallowing.

"I don't know," she admitted. "I think that might be the actual problem. Not him. Me asking."

The First No She Gave Back

The chance to practice arrived sooner than Grace expected, and from a direction she hadn't braced for: her mother-in-law, Beatrice, who called on a Wednesday to announce, not ask, that she'd be staying with them for three weeks starting Friday, "to help with the children" during a season when the children very plainly did not need help.

Grace's whole body knew the old response before her mind caught up to it — the automatic warmth, the automatic yes, the small rehearsed noises of welcome that she'd been making toward this woman for eleven years regardless of what she actually felt. She opened her mouth to make them now.

What came out instead surprised her as much as it would surprise Beatrice. "Mama, this isn't a good time. I have a lot on with the shop plans, and three weeks of hosting isn't something I can take on right now. Maybe in a couple of months, once things have settled."

The silence on the other end of the phone lasted long enough that Grace wondered if the call had dropped. "I see," Beatrice said finally, in a voice iced over with the particular offense of a woman unaccustomed to being told no by anyone, let alone her son's wife. "I'll speak to Musa about it."

She did. Musa came home that evening carrying the conversation like a weight he resented having to deliver. "My mother says you refused her."

"I did," Grace said, and felt her own pulse in her throat saying it. "Musa, I'm not trying to disrespect your mother. I'm telling you I don't have the capacity for a three-week stay right now, and I don't think that's an unreasonable thing to say."

"She's my mother, Grace. You don't refuse my mother."

"I'm not refusing her as a person. I'm setting a limit on what I can host, at this specific time, in my own house." Grace heard herself say "my own house" and understood, with a small shock, that she had never once in eleven years described it that way to him. "That's allowed to be true even if she's your mother."

They didn't resolve it that night, not cleanly. Musa was quiet in the particular way that meant disapproval he wasn't ready to argue directly, and Grace lay awake replaying the phone call, waiting for the guilt to arrive in its usual crushing volume. It arrived. It just didn't stay as long as she expected, or hit as hard. Underneath it, unfamiliar and a little frightening, was something that felt almost like relief — the specific relief of a muscle unclenching after years of being held tight without her noticing.

Beatrice did not speak to her for two weeks. Grace found, to her own quiet astonishment, that she survived it.

What Her Mother Never Got To Do

It was Faith who found the notebook, going through their late mother's things in the family house that none of the siblings had gotten around to fully clearing. A school exercise book, soft with age, filled front to back in Harriet's careful handwriting — prices, supplier names, a hand-drawn layout of a produce stall complete with where the scale would sit and which corner would catch the morning shade.

Faith brought it to Grace still dusty from the shelf. "She had the whole thing planned," Faith said, and her voice cracked slightly on it. "Look how detailed this is. She wasn't just dreaming, Grace. She had an actual plan. She just never—"

"She just never gave herself permission to stop asking," Grace finished, and the sentence landed in her own chest harder than she expected it to.

She sat with that notebook for a long time that night, tracing her mother's handwriting with one finger, and let herself feel something she'd been circling for months without naming directly: she was not afraid of failing at the tailoring shop. She was afraid of becoming her mother — of dying with a notebook full of a plan nobody ever told her she was allowed to start.

"I'm not going to let this be a drawing in a book," Grace said out loud, to no one, to the empty room, to her mother's handwriting. "I don't care what season anyone says it is."

She put the notebook on the shelf in the spare room, next to the sewing machines under their cloth, where she would see it every time she went in to work. Not as a decoration. As a witness.

The Room Full of No's

Grace paid the deposit on the shop space with money she no longer hid the source of — savings she'd quietly built for two years, finally spoken about out loud instead of folded into a story about her sister's wedding. Musa did not celebrate this. He also, notably, did not stop her, which Grace understood to be its own kind of answer, arrived at somewhere in the two weeks of Beatrice's silence and everything it had taught both of them.

The shop itself did not go well at first. This was the part Grace had not adequately prepared herself for — not the fight for permission, but the plain, unglamorous difficulty of the thing itself once permission stopped being the obstacle. Her first month's revenue barely covered the rent. A supplier she'd trusted delivered fabric in the wrong colors and refused a refund. A woman from church who'd promised, warmly, to be her first customer never actually came.

"Maybe Musa was right," Grace said to Faith one exhausted evening, the shop's lights off, the two of them sitting on overturned fabric bolts in the dark. "Maybe it wasn't the right time."

"Or maybe," Faith said, "it was never about the timing at all. Maybe some things are just hard, and you were taught to blame the hardness on bad timing so you'd have a reason to stop trying instead of a reason to try differently."

Grace turned that over for a long time. It didn't fix the wrong-colored fabric or bring back the promised customer. But it did something else, something she needed more than either of those: it let her be discouraged without deciding that discouragement was proof she'd been wrong to start.

She reordered the fabric from a different supplier. She adjusted her prices. She asked two of the women from her old sewing classes if they wanted part-time work once things picked up, a version of leadership she hadn't planned for and discovered she was better at than she expected. The room stayed full of no's for a while longer. She just stopped treating each one as a verdict on whether she should be there.

That Day She Became Her

A year after the deposit, Grace's shop had a name painted above the door — Harriet's Corner, after the notebook, after the woman who never got to stand in a room like this one — and enough steady customers that she'd taken on both women from the sewing classes properly, with wages and a schedule instead of favors.

Her daughter Patricia, twelve years old and still young enough to say exactly what she was thinking, stood in the doorway on opening day watching her mother adjust a dress on a mannequin, and asked the question Grace had been half-expecting and half-dreading for months.

"Mama, were you scared? Starting this?"

Grace considered lying, the way a certain kind of mother might, offering her daughter a clean and simple story about courage. She decided against it. "Terrified," she said instead. "I asked your father for permission for three years before I understood that the person I actually needed permission from was myself. And even after I understood that, I was still scared. I just stopped letting the fear be the one who decided."

Patricia considered this with the particular seriousness of a child filing something away for later use. "So being brave doesn't mean not being scared."

"No," Grace said. "Being brave means you stop waiting for the fear to leave before you start. It doesn't leave. You just stop needing it to."

She looked around the shop — the machines that had sat under a cloth for two years, the notebook now framed on the wall instead of hidden in a drawer, her daughter standing in the doorway watching her mother be a whole person instead of a woman waiting for someone else's yes. Grace Namono had spent nineteen years asking permission. It had taken one year of refusing to keep asking to become, finally, on an ordinary Tuesday with paint still drying above the door, the woman her own daughter was now watching to learn what was possible.

That was the day she became her. Not in a single dramatic moment, but in the accumulation of every small refusal that led here — and in the quiet certainty, standing in her own shop, that she would never again need anyone's permission to become the rest of what she was going to be.

If you're still breathing, your story isn't over.

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